

Checking out the political optics of Bell's AI data centre near Regina | CBC News

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Checking out the political optics of Bell's AI data centre near Regina Opponents of the project say they've felt it would move ahead no matter what An AI data centre that will cost \$1.7 billion and was endorsed by Premier Scott Moe received unanimous support from the council of a rural municipality where a majority of members were appointed recently by the provincial government. When the Rural Municipality of Sherwood's council held a vote approving the project, heavy equipment was already waiting on the parcel of land where construction is set to begin. For opponents of the project protesting outside the RM's office this week, the converging details are proof that it did not matter how vocal they were — construction of Canada's largest AI data centre would go ahead no matter what. Tom McIntosh, a professor of politics at the University of Regina, said that feeling is an unfortunate reality when people feel a process has not been transparent. "This is the kind of stuff around which we make conspiracy theories, right?" McIntosh said. The appointment of new councillors by the province and the vote on the project's development were all in line with the appropriate legislation, he added. The Government of Saskatchewan also highlighted that point when asked for comment. But McIntosh said that doesn't stop the AI data centre from becoming an issue of political optics for everyone involved. "The less transparency, the more there are these kinds of questions, the more people are going to say something was cooked, something smells, something is fishy here," he said. The information gap In February, CBC News broke the story that Bell Canada was planning to build an AI data centre near Regina. Although CBC reached out to Bell before publication and continued to do so as we published follow-up stories, the company either failed to respond or declined to comment, saying it had "no announcement to make at this time." It wasn't until March 16 that Bell finally confirmed it was behind the project. That's when Bell Canada CEO Mirko Bibic, visiting Regina and flanked by the premier, announced that the telecom giant would spend \$1.7 billion to construct a new data centre. "We're a 145-year-old company and this will be our largest ever investment in this province," Bibic said. The month that elapsed between CBC's reporting and Bell's official confirmation meant residents only had the sparse details contained in the RM of Sherwood's council agenda to understand the proposed project. Many people turned to existing reporting on concerns about data centres being built in other regions, including the United States. Even though Bell has indicated that its data centre won't be anywhere close to the water-guzzling projects found in other markets, the lack of details allowed an ocean of misinformation to fill the gap. Could providing more information have stopped people from opposing the project? It's not very likely.

There are established camps “for” and “against” AI-related projects. Outside of those two camps there is a much larger “middle” which could otherwise be ambivalent to the project, McIntosh said. “Those people in the middle, when they see what might be interpreted as shenanigans of some kind going on, that tends to push them one way or the other.” One of those potential issues is the vote by the RM’s council earlier this week. Its seven members unanimously approved the data centre’s development plan. Only three of them were elected and live in the RM. The remaining four — three councillors and the reeve — were appointed by the provincial government until elections are held in November. That can be a big problem when it’s a decision on something as big and controversial as this decision. “This is a really substantive, important vote. And so there are questions of the optics when a majority of that council is actually not elected,” McIntosh said. Ray Orb, the former president of the Saskatchewan Association of Rural Municipalities, was appointed to serve as the reeve. In an interview with CBC’s The 306, Orb insisted he was not questioned about his position on the AI data centre before he was appointed. In a statement, the provincial government said it contacts potential candidates based on experience and proximity to the municipality and is mindful to whether or not they have business or personal interests in the municipality that would put them in a conflict of interest. Although he admitted the optics of unelected councillors making such an important decision may not be great, Orb said he did his own research and that the council had the information necessary to make a decision. “The province announced it quite awhile ago that this project was going ahead, and so I think that’s why they brought us in, to keep this project going,” he said. Bell Canada insists that it has been transparent and the project “will bring significant benefits, employment opportunities and tax revenues to the community and to Saskatchewan.” The company said it’s committed to addressing the questions and concerns prompted by a project of this scale. “Throughout the development process, we have engaged continuously with residents and other stakeholders and adapted our plans based on feedback we have received,” Bell said in a prepared statement. It said that feedback resulted in some additional commitments laid out in the development agreement approved this week. The company pointed to a new website it believes will help people find answers to most questions about the project. Government responds The provincial government did not directly address a question on the concerns about optics. Instead, in a statement, it highlighted that the project “proceeded to a significant degree under the previous council,” referencing a special meeting held by the RM in February. “The Ministry of Government Relations can confirm the RM of Sherwood rezoned the land to facilitate the proposed development in February 2026, following a public hearing,” the government’s statement said. Minutes from the Feb. 9 special meeting indicate that the public hearing and second and third reading of the bylaw to rezone the 160-acre parcel of land to allow for a data centre took less than an hour. That meeting was also the first time the rezoning bylaw publicly referenced an AI data centre project. The agenda for the Jan. 19 council meeting made no mention of an AI data centre, only saying it was a rezoning application to change the parcel from agricultural to light industrial use. The first reading of the rezoning bylaw was passed by the RM’s council unanimously.